Folk/Lore

The Question of the 'Intelligent Average Individual'

Marc Alexander · WAW-ME, Zürich · January 2026

---

1 The Founding Ambition

'Put at its simplest, its purpose is to provide a detailed record of the English vocabulary from the earliest times to the present, with sufficient accompanying information that, for any given period in the past, the user should be able to ascertain the exact state of the vocabulary (i.e. the 'lexical system') which existed at that time.'

'Why a Historical Thesaurus'

- The claim: you can see what vocabulary was available at any point
- The complication: structures of the 'state of the vocabulary' are always from *some* perspective
- Three governing principles...

2 1: Folk Taxonomy

- 'What's it for?' rather than 'What is it?'
- Based on 'accidental rather than inherent properties'
- Classification reflects human functional perspective, not philosophical taxonomy
- Example: *writing desk*
  - Not: FURNITURE AND FITTINGS > DESK > WRITING DESK
  - But: COMMUNICATION > WRITING > WRITING MATERIALS > [...] > WRITING DESK
- (This is easier to explain for the concrete domains...)

3 2: Least Extension

- Place items in the narrowest, most specific category that fits
- Maintains semantic precision and keeps related vocabulary together
- But creates questions for compounds: *sea salt* under SALT or SEA?
- *Lava* classified with VOLCANO, *and* with IGNEOUS ROCK
- *Blasphemy* classified with WORSHIP, not SIN or LAW

4 3: Concrete to Abstract, General to Particular

- EXTERNAL WORLD → MENTAL WORLD → SOCIAL WORLD
- Rationale: concrete terms likely preceded abstract; metaphors for mental concepts derive from physical world
- Within categories: 'Begin with the most general and familiar, work through to the most specific and technical'

5 The 'Intelligent Average Individual'

- Our aim: 'a folk taxonomy, informed by what Hallig and von Wartburg describe as "naïve realism", setting forth "the intelligent average individual's view of the world, based on pre-scientific general concepts made available by language"'
- H&vW argued that a thesaurus should not 'correct' the language with one scientific viewpoint but should instead map the worldview embedded in the language itself
- This idea of a shared reality is a useful fiction
- It creates a general user whose worldview we can approximate
- But *when* and *whose* naïve realism?
- (H&vW implicitly assumed a Western European man.)

6 Specialisation as Spectrum

- 'Technical' vocabulary implies a binary: specialist vs general
- But specialisation is a continuum, not a category
- And the boundaries of specialist knowledge shift historically
- A physician's understanding of *melancholy* ≠ a poet's ≠ a priest's ≠ a patient's
- In a pre-scientific worldview, all of these are 'folk' understandings within their contexts
- And pre-scientific is a *terrible* concept; scholarship constantly reshapes 'folk' reality

7 Medieval Complications

- WAW-ME's four domains: EDUCATION, LAW, MEDICINE, RELIGION
- In this time period, these are not sealed professional spheres
  - Education primarily conducted by religious institutions
  - Law intertwined with religious authority
  - Medicine entangled with theology and natural philosophy
  - Religion can touch everything (perhaps...)
- 'Technical' vocabulary circulates across domains
- The 'intelligent average individual' might be literate, clergy-adjacent, and familiar with all four

8 What is lexicography for?

- Lexicography is for a *user*
- A conceptual structure is:
  - A finding aid
  - A navigation aid
  - A proximity browser
  - A means of clustering data
- It is tempting to view H&vW's 'intelligent average individual' as a contemporaneous speaker, but should it be an anachronistic user?
- For a technical domain, what is average?

Too Many Examples

- HT separates two related areas:
  - 01.17 THE SUPERNATURAL → EXTERNAL WORLD (explaining phenomena)
  - 03.07 FAITH → SOCIAL WORLD (organised religion as institution)
- Rationale: supernatural beings/manifestations vs social practice
- Works tolerably for Modern English, where many (?) speakers distinguish 'believing in vampires' from 'going to church'

9 But in Middle English…

- Where does *charm* go?
  - Medical practice? (remedy for illness)
  - Folk belief? (magical intervention)
  - Liturgical observation? (prayer, blessing, invocation)
  - All three simultaneously?
- Where does *blessing* go?
  - Priestly function (SOCIAL WORLD, FAITH)
  - Curative power (EXTERNAL WORLD? MEDICINE?)
  - State of being blessed (MENTAL WORLD?)
- The split assumes a modern separation of domains

10 The Body and Its Humours

- HT classifies body parts functionally
- *Tooth/teeth* → DIGESTIVE ORGANS (what they're for)
- But medieval medicine thought in terms of:
  - Humours (choler, melancholy, phlegm, blood)
  - Elements (hot/cold, wet/dry)
  - Correspondences (planets, seasons, temperaments)
- *Melancholy* in HT sits in MENTAL WORLD (EMOTION/TEMPERAMENT)
- But for medieval physicians, it's equally physical: black bile, spleen, digestion (Autumn, Saturn)
- When and whose 'folk' understanding governs?

11 The Humours in Classification

- *Choler*: a bodily fluid? a temperament? a disease? a sin (wrath)?
- *Phlegmatic*: describing what? body? personality? moral character?
- Modern categories separate:
  - Physical substance (EXTERNAL WORLD)
  - Psychological disposition (MENTAL WORLD)
  - Moral evaluation (SOCIAL WORLD)
- Does medieval usage separate these?
- Chaucer, *Nun's Priest's Tale:* 'the greete superfluytee/of youre rede colera' – the passage has a unified semantic concept (although complex), should all the concepts of these be really scattered around a thesaurus?

12 Legal-Religious Boundaries

- *Sanctuary*
  - A sacred place (FAITH)
  - A legal status (LAW)
  - A physical location (ARCHITECTURE/BUILDINGS)
- *Benefit of clergy*
  - A legal privilege
  - Defined by religious status
  - Tested by reading ability eg Ps. 51:1 (EDUCATION)
- *Heresy*
  - A belief (MENTAL WORLD)
  - A sin (FAITH)
  - A crime (LAW)
  - An institutional category (SOCIAL WORLD)

13 Where Does Penance Belong?

- Religious duty
- Legal remedy (in ecclesiastical courts?)
- Medical treatment (for spiritual sickness?)
- Educational process (moral correction?)
- HT places it in 12 places, many under WORSHIP but also SUFFERING, PUNISHMENT, VIRTUE, FOOD, and DEITY

14 Other Headaches You've Probably Already Had

- Blasphemy (SIN? LAW? WRONGDOING?)
- Heresy (WORSHIP? LAW? SIN?)
- Usury (SIN? TRADE?)
- Simony (COMMERCE? WORSHIP? SIN? LAW? CORRUPTION?)
- Tithe (TAX? RELIGIOUS ADMINISTRATION? AGRICULTURE? PROPORTION?)

15 Lump or Split

- Principle of least extension works well for monosemous terms
- But polysemous terms pull in multiple directions
- Do we:
  - Split senses across the hierarchy? (loses connections)
  - Keep senses together in one location? (distorts the category)
  - Cross-reference? (which is 'primary'?)
- HT generally splits by sense
- There's an aim to be isomorphic, sense-wise, with the OED
- But sometimes serving two structures means failing at both...

16 Cure

- Wycliffite Bible: 'cure of soulis'/'cure of siknesses' — same word, related concepts
- Spiritual sense: care of souls (*cura animarum*)
- Medical sense: treatment of disease
- These are etymologically and conceptually linked
- Splitting them across FAITH and MEDICINE loses something
- Keeping them together distorts both categories

17 Fear

- Should fear of God be near the fear of spiders?
- What do we gain and what do we lose by each option?
- *Are we importing the flaws of dictionaries to sit alongside the flaws of thesauruses to compound them?*

18 BTh Analogues

- Compared to everyday life, the learned professions are substantially *conceptual*
- What's missing from this hierarchy:
  - Concepts/Doctrines/Principles — where does *transubstantiation* go? *Habeas corpus?* Are the four humours instruments or materials?
  - Statuses/Conditions/States — *excommunicated, beneficed, in holy orders, under interdict*, relational and abstract concepts, are they agents?
  - Rights/Duties/Powers — legal and ecclesiastical vocabulary merges rights, obligations, privileges
  - Qualities/Properties — in medicine, hot, cold, wet, dry are diagnostic and therapeutic categories rather than substances

19 Open Questions

1. Should the 'intelligent average individual' be a medieval speaker or an anachronistic modern user? What changes if we choose one over the other?
2. The proposed hierarchy *(Agents/Practitioners, Locations/Institutions, Instruments, Processes, Materials/Substances/Objects, Documents)* works well for material culture. Will it do justice to concepts, statuses, doctrines, relationships, and rights?
3. Can 'folk taxonomy' apply to highly abstract concepts at all? Should fear of God sit near fear of spiders? What does 'what's it for?' mean when applied to sin, justice, or heresy?
4. Should polysemous terms be split (preserving category coherence) or kept together (preserving semantic connections)? Or are we compounding dictionary flaws with thesaurus flaws?
5. For a specialised domain, what counts as 'average'? Who navigates a thesaurus of learned professions, and what are they looking for?